Incendiary

By Chris Cleave

WIFE: **(Pg 29-30)** *(to husband)* I wish you wouldn't take the boy to the game. He's too little. The violence makes me nervous.

HUSBAND: *(laughing)* Crowd violence at a football game. That's a laugh considering I defuse bombs for a living. Listen love, football crowds aren't how they used to be. It's a family game now and anyway I'm a copper. I'm a big bloke I can handle myself.

WIFE: It's not you I'm worried about. It's the boy. He is 4 years old [and] still sleeps with Mr. Rabbit. *(holds and interacts with Mr. Rabbit throughout the selection)* **(Pg 11)** *(to audience)* I sewed Mr. Rabbit myself he was purple with green ears.

HUSBAND: **(Pg 30)** Oh for Christ's sake, said my husband. You think I don't look after him? You think I'd let anyone touch a hair on his head? I'd kill them first.

WIFE: Alright. But it still makes me nervous.

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HUSBAND: Everything makes you nervous.

WIFE: *(to audience)* And he was right. Oh, god, he was absolutely right. I could feel death rushing towards us. **(Pg 39-40)** It was May 1st and the sky was blue and it was nice and warm just like you want it to be on May Day. My husband was carrying the boy on his shoulders and both of them were grinning like idiots. They were wearing their Arsenal shirts because it was Saturday -- the big day. They climbed in our old Astra and drove off. I never saw my husband or my boy again.

INTRODUCTION

On July 7, 2005, during the morning rush hour, four bombs were detonated in the center of London killing 52 and injuring over 770 others. Three IED's exploded in underground stations and the fourth on a bus. The attacks were inspired by al-Qaeda and its ideology.

On that same day, Chris Cleave's debut novel was published: the fictional story of what happens after a bomb kills more than 1,000 people in a London soccer stadium as told through the eyes of a young mother. It is hard to imagine an uglier "literature echoes reality" coincidence.

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RADIO ANNOUNCER: **(Pg 73)** THE NUMBER OF CONFIRMED DEAD FROM THE MAY DAY ATTACK HAS RISEN TO 966 WITH DOZENS MORE STILL MISSING OR IN CRITICAL CONDITION.

WIFE: **(Pg 76-77)** They reckon 200 people died straight away -- blown to bits by the fragmentation bombs. I hope my husband and my boy were part of that 200. That's a funny thing to say isn't it? But that is what I hope. Because the 200 people who died straight away didn't have to suffer.

After the first blast anyone who could still run did run. There was an inferno. Phosphorus raining down all around. It set fire to the seats. To the stands. To the clothes and skin of the fallen bodies. They reckon 500 people were crushed and burned to death while fire rained down. They would swing open the ambulance doors and blood would be an inch deep on the floor. They said some of the *(pause)* ***things*** *(pause)* that arrived on the ambulance stretchers didn't really look like anything.

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Dear Osama . . . **(Pg 73)** They kept calling it The Catastrophe. The BBC never did work out what to call the thing you'd blown up. After days of calling it the Emirates Stadium or Gunners Park, they gave up and started calling the whole thing May Day. Everyone did. Like you hadn't just blown up a football ground you'd blown a hole straight through our calendar. I felt like I'd fallen through the hole.

BOY: **(Pg 228)** Mummy . . . Mummy, why don't you help me?

WIFE: **(Pg 4)** You can see what a boy really is from the shape of the hole he leaves behind. I want you to feel that hole in your heart, Osama. Stroke it with your hands and cut your fingers on its sharp edges.

(Pg 163) Everything happened in the spring and it never stopped for one second. It was dirty and sad and anyone who wasn't blown up and burned -- It was like we all became animals again. You could look at people on the bus and you'd almost see the fur bristling under their nice clean clothes. After May Day everyone was nervous. It wasn't just me anymore.

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(Pg 27) They say you are a FIEND, Osama, but like I say I don't believe a word of it. I've seen you in your videos. You give me the shivers and you look like a gentleman. They say you believe in paradise. They say you believe that if your people kill anyone innocent then you're doing them a favour because they will go to be with Allah. I wouldn't know about that. My husband didn't believe in Allah he believed in his kid and Arsenal football club.

(Pg 27-29) I always liked the football but my husband and my boy were mad for it. The fun used to start the night before. Before we put the boy to bed my husband would run around the flat with the boy on his shoulders. They would sing *1 NIL TO THE ARSENAL till the upstairs neighbours banged on the ceiling. After the singing the boy would be laughing and giggling like a lunatic. We couldn't get him to sleep. *(flashback to a memory)*

BOY: Mum! Mum, mum, mum, come quick there's something in my room.

WIFE: What is it? I'd say.

BOY: Nothing *(giggling)* I fooled you!

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WIFE: *(to audience)* He was 4 years and 3 months old. You couldn't be cross with him. That boy had such a beautiful smile. He was just pleased to be alive. *(to boy)* Go to sleep, little monster or you'll be tired for the big game.

BOY: But I'm not sleepy mum,

WIFE: Go to sleep or I'll have to fetch your father.

BOY: I'm not scared of him! My dad is the best dad in the world! He's better than. Than. Than.

WIFE: Than what? Eh, little monster? What's your dad better than?

BOY: *(erupting in giggles again)* Monkeys! My dad is better than monkeys!

WIFE: **(Pg 11)** (beat, then to audience) In the night my boy's room smelled of boy. Boy is a good smell it is a cross between angels and tigers. My boy slept on his side sucking Mr. Rabbit's paws. He went everywhere my boy went. **(Pg 37)** I've gone through a lot of changes since then Osama but if you looked very carefully and the light was right, I expect you could still see the memory of that happy time in me. Hidden but not quite invisible *(beat)* **(Pg 11)** Mr. Rabbit survived.

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still have him. His green ears are black with blood and one of his paws is missing. *(beat)* **(Pg 101)** A lot of things survived because they were trapped under bodies. *(gasp)*

(Pg 29) It sounds silly, Osama, but sometimes I'm pleased your people blew them both up together. **(Pg 117)** All they found was their teeth and Mr. Rabbit.

(Pg 311) The only thing going through my head? My boy screaming with Mr. Rabbit in his pocket and his Arsenal shirt in flames.

BOY: **(Pg 262)** Mummy, save me!

WIFE: **(Pg 295)** *(puts hands to her mouth to stifle a silent scream)* His lovely ginger hair burned. Thick black tar dripping down his face. His skin raw with burns and one of his eyes boiled white as an egg.

(Pg 209) Mr. Rabbit stained black with my boy's blood -- scars where his skin had burned through and his stuffing roasted brown and hard as crackling.

(Pg 137-138) [They say] the Arabs are different from us. In the Iran/Iraq war they sent children to walk across the minefields. To clear a path so the grown ups

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could go and gas each other. They gave each kid a little metal key to paradise. The kids hung those keys around their necks. The grown-up Arabs told the little Arab children that there weren't enough landmines to send all the kids to paradise. So the little children actually ran. Kids will believe anything you tell them . . . *(long beat)*

(Pg 71-73) Well Osama I sometimes think we deserve whatever you do to us. Maybe you are right maybe we are infidels. Even when you blow us into chunks we don't stop fighting each other. I suppose you were sitting out on the rocks before dawn listening to the goat bells when one of your men came over to you. Did he say, "Hey boss turn on the radio! We did it! We blew up Arsenal's shiny new stadium1" ? Did you smile? Did you turn on the radio and listen to the death toll rise? *(beat)*

I fell unconscious and I stayed that way for 3 days. When I woke up in hospital. The sheets were very stiff and white. The radio was on in the ward. 912 dead it said. At first they said 700 dead but it went up and up. The survivors wouldn't stop dying you see. They had

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so many bits blown off them they couldn't really help themselves. There was a BRAVE 82 YR OLD GRAN in the bed across from me. She'd lost both eyes at the stadium and she was singing 1 NIL TO THE ARSENAL again and again and again. *(covers ear, cradles Mr. Rabbit and wimpers, then gathers herself to continue the story)*

(Pg 86-88) Mena was my favourite nurse. She was a nice girl. She was from the East. Kazakhstan or Uzbekistan or one of those Stans anyway. She'd sit on the end of my bed and we'd watch the sun rising. Mena used to hold my hand while we looked out over the city.

MENA: So many people down there. So many people under this sunrise. And all those people want is to get through today.

WIFE: Mena was like that. Philosophical. *(contemplative beat)* I'd definitely of killed myself if it hadn't of been for her. *(beat)* Each morning [we] watched what they were doing to London. First, they stopped boats using the river. They just stopped them so you couldn't blow up the Houses of Parliament, Osama. They drained the

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life out of the river till it was just an empty vein with police boats drifting up and down it like white blood cells. **(Pg 102)** For a whole week after May Day the airports stayed closed.

(Pg 88) What really changed the view though was the barrage balloons shining silver in the rising sun. It gave me the shivers. Mena gripped my hand and I could see the goose bumps on her arm.

MENA: This is grotesque. The world has gone crazy.

WIFE: It makes sense to me. I reckon it's to stop them flying planes into the tall buildings.

MENA: **(Pg 89-90)** We turn London into a fortress? As if that could possibly stop the terror.

WIFE: *(to audience)* I could feel Mena's hand trembling. I watched a tear run down the side of her nose. It stopped on her upper lip. *(to Mena)* If you had kids, you'd be all for anything they can do against the terrorists. It doesn't matter if it's logical when it's your own kids.

MENA: It matters if you're Asian. Look, my family is Muslim right. Do you have any idea what it's been like for us? I don't think you can imagine how it feels for

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me just to walk to work since May Day. To see the hate in people's eyes when they look at me. I have become the enemy. There's this one cafe I walk past on my way here. This morning this old man, he must have been 80, was reading the paper and the headline on the paper was THE CRUELTY OF ISLAM. He looked up when I walked past and he sneered at me. He actually curled his lips. That is the nature of this madness. It fills the sky with barrage balloons and people's eyes with hate.

WIFE: **(Pg 91-92)** Mena gave me this lovely smile and touched her right hand to her heart.

MENA: I must go . . .

WIFE: I'll see you tomorrow. *(to audience)* But I didn't. In fact, I never did see Mena again. The next morning the sun turned up just like normal, but Mena didn't. A new nurse came instead. *(to nurse)* What happened to Mena?

NURSE: They stopped her working. Muslim wasn't she? Security risk. They suspended all of them from working as of midnight. This country's finally starting to get it. Don't get me wrong. I'm sure 99 percent of the

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Muslims are fine but if you can't trust some of them you can't trust any of them can you?

WIFE: But they can't just stop all the Muslims from working.

NURSE: Oh, they haven't. Only the ones who fly planes and work in hospitals or have access to information.

WIFE: *(with great sorrow)* The new nurse didn't hold my hand. She didn't watch the sunrise with me. **(Pg 136)** You really think it was Islam that killed my husband and my boy? [Mena] was the gentlest woman I ever met. Her god wasn't a bombing god.

BOY: **(Pg 271)** Mummy, why are you crying?

WIFE: *(to Mr. Rabbit)* Mummy's not crying darling. Mummy's fine. She's just got something in her eye. **(Pg 235-236)** Before you bombed my boy, Osama, I always thought an explosion was such a quick thing but now I know better. The flash is over very fast but the fire catches hold inside you and the noise never stops. . . I live in an inferno where you shiver with cold. This life is a deafening roar . . . but listen. You could hear a pin drop.

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